

So now consider a possible scenario in which someone exactly like you would get a Predictor. By the above line of thought, this person would lack free will. But that Predictor did not **take away** their free will; it just shows them that they never had any. So they lacked free will before getting a Predictor.

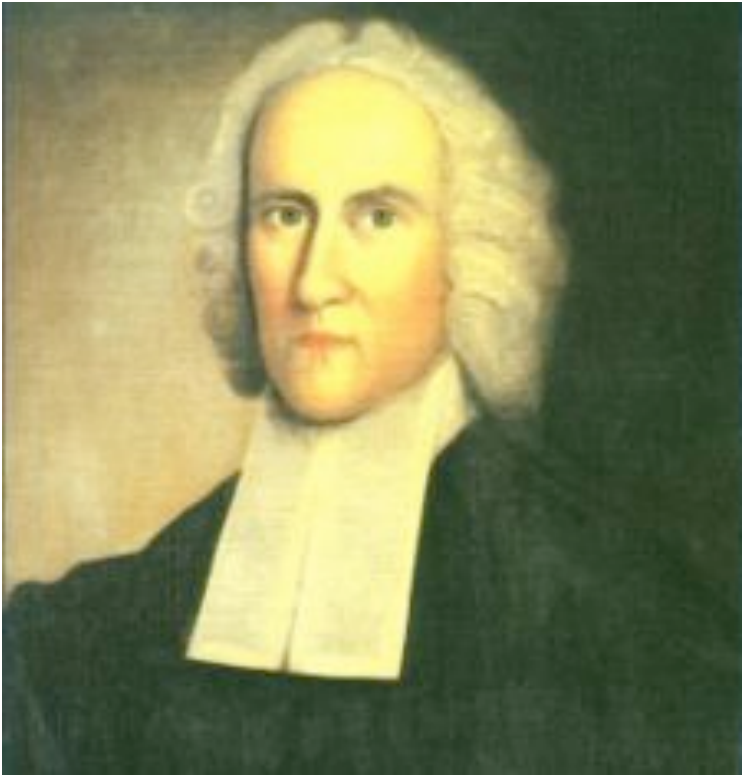
But this person was stipulated to be exactly like you. So you don't have free will,
either.

So far we've looked at two imaginary thought experiments — the story of Osmo, and the example of the Predictor — which seem to show that if there is such a thing as fate, then there is no free will.

They do. The best way to see how this argument might work is to start with the challenge posed by God's foreknowledge of our actions. We'll come back to fate after that.

The argument we're going to talk about is due to Jonathan Edwards.

Edwards was an 18th century American philosopher, theologian and preacher, perhaps best known now for his sermon, "Sinners in the Hands of An Angry God."



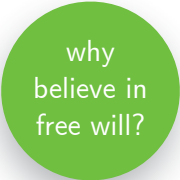
Our question is: do either fate or foreknowledge pose a serious challenge to the reality of free will?



two
arguments
against free
will



is fate
real?



why
believe in
free will?



three
ways out

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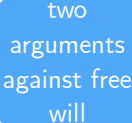


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serious challenge to the reality of free will?

Our first topic today is the oldest challenge to the existence of free will: the challenge to

freedom that comes from fate.



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argument might be related to an argument

We'll shortly consider some ways of

responding to Edwards' argument. But

first let's think about how Edwards'

there were truths about all our future

similar to Edwards' argument?

actions. Could they give an argument

Suppose that someone did not believe in

Edwards' argument — but did believe that

God— and hence rejected premise (2) of

replace reference to God's foreknowledge

our future actions.

God only shows up in premises (2) and

with reference to the being of truth about

(5) Let's look at what happens if we



1. We have no direct facts.

5* We have noticed that the fact

God knows that in the future I will

will perform various actions.

perform a certain action (1,2)

then we have the choice about q.

2* In the past, there were truths about

3 We have not the fact that

choice about the fact that if p , then q ,

that if it is true that I will perform

acaioid.

all of our activities.

4. If we have no choice about p , and no

0 We have achieved what we



some action, then I will prefer that

(3, 4, 5)

The fatalist argument

One might wonder: can we come up with an argument which starts with the

reality of fate — i.e., the reality of truth about the future — and use this to

show that free will is an illusion?

is the challenge posed by God's foreknowledge of our actions.

We can. The best way to show this argument might work is to start with a

challenge to free will which is closely related to the challenge posed by fate. This

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